TALK FOUR

4 An Elias

"Suffer it to be so now: for thus it becometh us to fulfil all righteousness."

MATTHEW 3:15

When Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan River to be baptized, John tried to stop Him. "I have need to be baptized of thee," he said, "and comest thou to me?" John baptized people who were repenting of their sins. Jesus had none. John recognized Him as his Lord, so it seemed that they should trade places. But Jesus answered, "Suffer it to be so now: for thus it becometh us to fulfil all righteousness." Suffer here means allow. John accepted what the Lord asked and baptized Him.

Jesus's baptism showed that even the Lord we follow submitted to His Father. Nephi explained that Jesus humbled Himself before the Father and showed His willingness to obey Him. He also showed us the way. If Jesus, who was holy, needed to be baptized, how much more do we need it? Baptism is the gate, and He went through it ahead of us. John's work of preparing the way for the Lord brought him to this moment, helping the Savior fulfill what His Father required.

John could perform that baptism because he held authority from God. Doctrine and Covenants 84 traces the lesser priesthood through Aaron's family down to John. It says John was baptized as a child and ordained when he was eight days old "to make straight the way of the Lord before the face of his people, to prepare them for the coming of the Lord." Both his parents descended from Aaron, and his appointment came from heaven. Joseph Smith taught that Jesus "had no legal administrator" on the earth except John. Jesus came to the only man authorized to perform the ordinance.

The word baptism also helps us picture what happened in the Jordan. The Greek word was used for things submerged or thoroughly soaked—even, in one expression, for someone "over head and ears in debt." John Taylor remembered Joseph Smith pointing out that the German Bible calls John "John the Dipper." John put people beneath the water and brought them up

again. His authority and the way he performed the ordinance were both part of the work given to him.

The scriptures call this work of preparing the way the work of an Elias. Gabriel told Zacharias that John would go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias." Elias is the Greek form of Elijah, but it can also be a title for someone sent to prepare for a work that's coming. This helps explain something that can be confusing when we read about John. When people asked whether he was Elias, he said no. Yet Jesus later said Elias had already come, and His disciples understood that He meant John the Baptist.

Joseph Smith's translation helps us distinguish the callings described by that title. John said, "I am not that Elias who was to restore all things." A few verses later, he spoke of Jesus: "He is that prophet, even Elias, who, coming after me, is preferred before me." John had a work of preparation to do, but he was not claiming every work associated with the title of Elias. His answer directed people toward the One who would come after him.

Other scriptures use Elias for more than one person as well. In a revelation to Joseph Smith, the Lord says Elias appeared to Zacharias and promised him a son who would be "filled with the spirit of Elias." Luke calls that messenger Gabriel, and Joseph Smith taught that Gabriel was Noah. In that story, one Elias announced the coming of another. The Lord also applied the title to John the Revelator in connection with gathering Israel. The name describes a calling that different servants of God have fulfilled.

For John the Baptist, the calling has clear responsibilities and limits. Joseph Smith explained that "the spirit of Elias is to prepare the way for a greater revelation of God" and connected it with the priesthood of Aaron. John preached repentance and baptized, but he could not confer the gift of the Holy Ghost. He told the people that the One coming after him would baptize "with the Holy Ghost and with fire." Joseph Smith said John "did not transcend his bounds, but faithfully performed that part belonging to his office." John understood what he was authorized to do and gave himself to that work. When people needed what he could not give, he pointed them to the Lord.

This same Aaronic priesthood was needed when Joseph Smith and Oliver Cowdery learned about baptism while translating the Book of Mormon. Reading about the ordinance did not give them authority to perform it. In May 1829, they went into the woods to pray. A heavenly messenger appeared in a cloud of light and laid his hands on them, saying, "Upon you my fellow servants, in the name of Messiah I confer the Priesthood of Aaron, which holds the keys of the ministering of angels, and of the gospel of repentance, and of baptism by immersion for the remission of sins." The messenger identified himself as John the Baptist.

The Restoration also prepared the way for the Lord's coming. In a revelation to Joseph Smith, the Lord repeated Isaiah's words: "Prepare ye the way of the Lord, make his paths straight." Joseph Smith was an Elias too. John prepared people to receive Jesus during His mortal life. The work Joseph Smith accomplished began to prepare the earth for His return. In both, repentance and baptism are the first steps in being ready to receive the Lord.

John's life shows how much can be accomplished through the Aaronic Priesthood. He received the ministrations of angels. He preached repentance, baptized, and helped people change their lives. He prepared them to receive the Savior and then sent them to Him. He understood the limits of his authority without treating his responsibility as small.

Many of us in this room hold the priesthood of Aaron like John. It still holds the keys of the ministering of angels, the gospel of repentance, and baptism. It can prepare and pass the sacrament. We have authority to preach repentance and baptize when called on. These ordinances lead people to the Savior and teach how to follow Him. John gave himself completely to the work he was called to do. He didn't even worry about his clothes or food. I have to ask myself if I'm using the priesthood I hold as fully as he used his.

MY TESTIMONY

As I think about how John the Baptist dedicated his life to the work he was called to do, it makes me think about how dedicated I am in my own life to the gospel. I've noticed that a lot of times I don't do even the little things, like reading 15 minutes of scripture a day or saying my morning and nighttime prayers, or even paying attention in Sunday School or church. I begin to get lazy about what I believe and let my thoughts wander into bad habits. I am actively building my testimony, and I believe that when I do the simple things, it builds good habits. It helps me stay focused on my goals and helps me magnify the commitments I've made by taking on the Aaronic Priesthood. I've learned that it's not that the gospel isn't true or that Heavenly Father is far away. It's that I'm not doing my part to stay close to Him. And I say these things in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

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